**International Student Housing – Deliverable #4**


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FUTURE STATE JOURNEY MAP

# International Student Housing

From uncertainty to confidence: A seamless, survey-driven journey

## STAGE 1
## AWARENESS

**ACTIONS**

Learns about official verified housing portal and gets
How housing works in Boston guide from university

**THOUGHTS AND FEELING**

*This is official and safe. I finally know where to start.*
→ **Informed instead of lost**

**PAIN POINTS**

✓ No longer relies on random social media groups

**IMPROVEMENTS**

University-vetted portal early in admission plus safety module

## STAGE 2
## RESEARCH

**ACTIONS**

Logs in uses filters for budget safety commute time
browses verified listings with photos and maps

**THOUGHTS AND FEELING**

*I can clearly see which options are affordable and safe.*
→ **More in control less anxious**

**PAIN POINTS**

✓ Incomplete or outdated listings are rare

**IMPROVEMENTS**

Verified badges safety indicators commute maps standard fields

STAGE 3

## SHORTLISTING

### ACTIONS

Saves options uses total-cost calculator rent plus utilities plus fees reads international student reviews

### THOUGHTS AND FEELING

*I understand the full cost and what students experienced.*

→ **Confident and reassured**

### PAIN POINTS

✓ Hidden costs greatly reduced by calculator

### IMPROVEMENTS

Total-cost calculator affordability guidance student reviews

STAGE 4

## APPLICATION

### ACTIONS

Applies through portal messages landlords via secure translated chat uploads lease for plain-language review

### THOUGHTS AND FEELING

*I understand my lease and what I am signing.*

→ **Protected instead of stressed**

### PAIN POINTS

✓ Lease terms and guarantor requirements clearer

### IMPROVEMENTS

Step-by-step checklist plain-language summaries alternatives

STAGE 5

## CONFIRMATION

**ACTIONS**

Receives digital confirmation pack with lease summary
payment schedule pre-arrival checklist books move-in slot

**THOUGHTS AND FEELING**

*All the steps and deadlines are clear. I feel ready to move.*
→ **Relieved and prepared**

**PAIN POINTS**

✓ Fear of place not matching photos reduced through tours

**IMPROVEMENTS**

Pre-arrival pack with checklist transit info virtual orientation

STAGE 6

## MOVE IN

**ACTIONS**

Follows First Week Guide sets up utilities and WiFi
submits maintenance tickets connects with roommate

**THOUGHTS AND FEELING**

*If something goes wrong I know exactly where to get help.*
→ **Supported and feeling at home**

**PAIN POINTS**

✓ Utility setup and maintenance issues still occur but tracked

**IMPROVEMENTS**

In-app maintenance tracker emergency info roommate matching

## Introduction and Journey Map Connection

This Behavior Change Package presents three strategically designed interventions derived from our Future State Journey Map for international students navigating the housing process. Our journey map analysis revealed critical pain points across four key stages: Awareness & Research, Selection & Visit Preparation, Commitment & Confirmation, and Post-Move Adjustment.

### Connecting Actions to the Journey Map

The three actions in this package directly address the highest-risk moments identified in our future state journey map:

**Action 1: Plain-Language Lease Review Tool** addresses the Commitment & Confirmation stage, where our journey map revealed that students experience peak anxiety due to unfamiliar legal terminology, fear of hidden costs, and pressure to sign quickly.

**Action 2: Financial Readiness Assessment** addresses the Awareness & Research stage, where our journey map identified that students begin their search without understanding true affordability, leading to wasted time and emotionally-driven decisions.

**Action 3: Neighborhood Safety & Amenities Report** addresses the Selection & Visit Preparation stage, where our journey map showed that students struggle to evaluate location safety and rely on unreliable peer advice or fragmented online information.

Together, these interventions create a layered protective architecture that supports students at each critical transition in the housing value stream.

## Action 1:

**Students upload their housing lease into the Plain-Language Review tool before signing**

**What the User Should Do**

Before signing any agreement, the student should upload the housing lease document into the university's Plain-Language Review tool to obtain a simplified, risk-highlighted explanation of terms, fees, obligations, and possible legal ramifications.

**Why This Action Is Essential**

Due to uncertainty, emotional strain, and cognitive overload, signing a lease is the most dangerous part of the housing journey for students. Key pain points identified by the journey map include pressure to find housing quickly, fear of hidden costs or scams, and unfamiliar legal terminology.

Processes that lower stakeholder risk, improve clarity, and offer trustworthy knowledge resources at crucial times must be designed by organizations (Yeats, 2007). Users use heuristics, steer clear of details, or take emotionally motivated shortcuts when faced with complicated or unclear information (Wendel, 2020). A Plain-Language Review tool enhances decision quality, minimizes friction, and lessens cognitive load.

This action is in line with business architecture principles that emphasize capability enablement, clear process pathways, and high-quality information assets that support stakeholder decisions. In order to feel confident and lessen decision stress, people navigating uncertain or high-stakes situations need structured guidance and communication, according to research on organizational change (Hartge et al., 2015). Yeats goes on to say that cognitive overload impairs analytical processing and raises the risk of mistakes at difficult decision points (Yeats, 2007). Thus, a streamlined review tool serves as crucial cognitive support.

## CREATE Funnel

### Cue

During the housing application process, a prompt instructs students:
"Before signing, upload your lease to receive a Plain-Language Review of key risks and obligations."
Providing this cue at the moment of need improves activation and reduces mental effort (Wendel, 2020).

### Reaction

Students often feel relief because the tool simplifies legal content, but they may also feel anxious about potential negative findings. Emotional ambivalence is typical in high-stakes contexts and shapes follow-through (Wendel, 2020).

### Evaluation

Students evaluate whether the tool appears credible, uses trusted institutional language, highlights relevant clauses clearly, and reduces ambiguity. High-quality information strengthens trust and supports effective decision-making (Yeats, 2007).

### Ability

Ability improves when the tool includes simple uploading features, fast automated analysis, color-coded clause summaries, translated explanations, and examples of student-friendly patterns. Reducing complexity helps users follow through on demanding tasks (Wendel, 2020). Reducing mental burden also supports clearer processing during complex business decisions (Yeats, 2007).

### Timing

The review must occur before signing to prevent irreversible commitments and reduce downstream risk. Correct timing protects value and prevents errors in decision-intensive processes (Yeats, 2007).

**Biases and Heuristics**

The following cognitive biases make this intervention essential:

**Status Quo Bias**

Students may skip review because signing quickly feels easier.

**Authority Bias**

Students may assume the landlord's document is automatically trustworthy.

**Information Avoidance**

Students may avoid reviewing legal material due to anxiety or anticipated stress.

**Optimism Bias**

Students may underestimate potential risks or penalties.

These biases increase vulnerability, making the intervention essential.

**Habits to Consider**

- Little experience with U.S. rental law
- Exposure to simpler rental processes in previous countries
- Habit of skimming documents rather than reviewing details
- Reliance on peer opinions instead of structured tools
- Pressure to act quickly due to perceived housing scarcity

These habits heighten risk without system-level support.

**Behavior Design Recommendations**

**1. Mandatory Review Step**

Requiring a lease review before submission ensures protective actions at the key decision point and reduces user risk (Yeats, 2007).

**2. Color-Coded Clause Warnings**

Red for high-risk, yellow for uncommon, green for standard—reducing cognitive load and improving comprehension (Wendel, 2020).

**3. Trust Signals**

Labels such as "Reviewed using university housing standards" increase trust and reduce hesitation.

**4. Social Proof**

Messages such as "Most students complete a lease review before signing" create normative expectations that increase compliance.

**5. Micro-Learning Snippets**

Brief explanations of lease concepts (e.g., "guarantor," "early termination fee") increase user confidence.

**6. Capability Alignment**

The Plain-Language Review tool serves as a knowledge-enabling capability that strengthens the housing value stream and supports the organizational capability of "Risk Mitigation & Stakeholder Support."

## Action 2:

**Students Complete a Financial Readiness Assessment Before Housing Search**

**What the User Should Do**

We strongly encourage all students to take a required Financial Readiness Assessment prior to beginning their housing search. It will compute their realistic budget, factoring in sources of income, and provide them individually with spending benchmarks while generating a range of affordable housing. This should be done before accessing the university's portal or any other third-party listings for housing.

**Why This Action Is Essential**

This journey map shows that the most critical pain points for international students are related to the financial planning stage of their journey: uncertainty about the total costs beyond rent, confusion about U.S. banking and methods of payments, and fear of overcommitting financially.

According to Burlton (2015), business architecture must align capabilities, processes, and information to deliver value at moments when stakeholders are most vulnerable to poor decisions.

Financial miscalculation represents a high-stakes capability gap in the housing value stream. Students entering the housing market without understanding their true affordability range make emotionally-driven decisions under time pressure, leading to lease commitments they cannot sustain (Wendel, 2020). As Burlton points out, information architecture is required to provide the right information, in the right form, at the right time to enable capability execution (Burlton, 2015). A Financial Readiness Assessment works like a decision-enabling information asset that enhances the "Financial Planning & Resource Allocation" capability within the housing value stream.

Research on organizational process design indicates that preventive interventions at early stages reduce costly corrections downstream (Burlton, 2015). When students start searching without financial clarity, they waste time viewing inappropriate properties, experience anxiety due to mismatched expectations, and face potential homelessness or financial crisis in the middle of the semester. The assessment shifts the organization from a reactive problem-solving approach to a proactive capability-building approach. This aligns with the business architecture principles in the context of enabling capability, clear pathways for processes, high-quality information assets that inform key decision points of stakeholders.

**CREATE Funnel**

**Cue**

Once students log in to the housing portal, they are taken through a necessary checkpoint: "Complete your Financial Readiness Assessment to unlock housing listings matched to your budget." The cue is contextually embedded in the natural workflow, making it impossible to bypass while framing completion as enabling rather than restrictive (Wendel, 2020). Burlton says process touchpoints need to take the stakeholder through capability execution at natural decision gates.

**Reaction**

Students might feel initial frustration because of the extra step, but they are quickly relieved by seeing personalized, realistic numbers. The tool validates their concerns and provides emotional

reassurance through concrete planning. Emotional ambivalence is typical in high-stakes contexts and shapes follow-through.

**Evaluate**

The credibility of the tool is realised by students through university branding, individualised calculations based on real financial inputs, comparison to peer benchmarks-anonymised data showing "students with similar funding typically budget X"-and clear explanation of the calculation methodology. Burlton reinforces the importance of information quality on stakeholder trust in organisational processes. High quality information strengthens trust and supports effective decision-making (Yeats, 2007).

**Ability**

This tool enhances capability through the use of simple input fields with examples, auto-calculations for the 30% income rule and utilities estimates, visual budget breakdowns using pie charts, downloadable budget worksheets to refer to during viewings, multilanguage support of financial terminology, and mobile optimization. Burlton's capability mapping framework illustrates how enabling mechanisms, or tools, templates, and systems, directly support the performance of capabilities. It reduces complexity, helping users to follow through on demanding tasks (Wendel, 2020).

**Timing**

The assessment takes place at the ideal point of intervention: after students have decided to seek housing but before they start considering specific properties. This avoids the problem of them investing time in viewing properties that they cannot afford and falling in love with a property they will never afford, only to panic and make hurried, often bad, decisions near deadlines. Burlton indicates that process sequencing must follow natural stakeholder decision flows while injecting protective checkpoints at transitions with high risk. Timing that is correct saves value and prevents mistakes from occurring in intensive decision processes.

**Biases and Heuristics**

- Present Bias - Students are concerned with securing housing now and they underestimate the stress of future monthly payment. The assessment makes future costs salient in present decision-making.
- Anchoring bias: Students anchor to the first rent price they see, or what somebody else tells them constitutes a reasonable price. The tool provides a personalized anchor based on actual income.
- Planning Fallacy-Students underestimate total housing costs because they forget utilities, renters insurance, furniture, and deposits. The assessment covers all cost categories.
- Overconfidence Effect: Students feel they can "make it work" financially without detailed planning. The tool provides realistic projections that counter unwarranted optimism.
- Availability Heuristic – Students make decisions based on easily recalled examples (friends' situations) rather than their own financial reality. The assessment grounds decisions in personal data.

These biases increase vulnerability, hence making the intervention essential.

**Habits to Consider**

Limited budgeting experience (most have never handled monthly expenses independently); dependence on parental support, but with poor communication about how much is ongoing; currency confusion and lack of understanding about what USD can purchase; social comparison orientation to accommodation choice against personal affordability; optimistic estimation habits; and financial planning avoidance as a function of anxiety. Such behavioral patterns create vulnerability in the absence of structured intervention that aligns with Burlton's capability-enabling architecture. Pressure to act fast and habit of avoiding detailed financial analysis heighten risk without system-level support.

**Behavior Design Recommendations**

1. **Compulsory Checkpoint Integration**: The need for assessment completion prior to portal access ensures protective actions at the key decision point, minimizing user risk. According to Burlton, processes should embed the requirements for capability execution at critical gates.

**2. Immediate Feedback Loops**: Real-time updates showing "Your affordable rent range: $800–$1,000" as students input data. Instant feedback increases perceived value and reduces abandonment while improving comprehension (Wendel, 2020).

**3. Comparative Benchmarking with Social Proof:** Anonymous data like "Students in your program typically budget $950/month for rent." Messages like "Most students complete this assessment before searching" build normative expectations that increase compliance and set realistic expectations.

**4. Consequence Visualization:** "If you spend $1,200/month on rent, you'll have $150 remaining for food and transportation" makes trade-offs concrete. Burlton says decision visualization tools are critical information assets that support stakeholder capability performance.

**5. Gamified Completion with Progress Indicators:** Activate the progress bar displaying "3 of 5 sections completed" and include motivational messages. Trust signals like "Calculated using university financial aid standards" increase trust and reduce hesitation.

**6. Integration of Micro-Learning:** Quick definitions of financial concepts, such as "security deposit," "utilities average," and "30% rule," placed contextually throughout, build user confidence and reduce cognitive load when processing complex information (Yeats, 2007).

**7. Capability Alignment and Value Stream Integration:** The Financial Readiness Assessment acts as a knowledge enablement capability to enhance the housing value stream across various organizational capabilities such as Risk Mitigation & Stakeholder Support-to avert financial crisis scenarios, Information Management-to provide structured financial data, Decision Enablement-to help make informed choices, and Process Efficiency-to limit wasted time searching. Burlton's framework illustrates that good business architecture mapping among processes, capabilities, and enabling tools is essential for effective and sustainable stakeholder value delivery.

## Action 3:

**Students Receive a Neighborhood Safety & Amenities Report Before Scheduling Any Housing Visit**

**What the User Should Do**

Before scheduling a viewing or contacting a landlord, the student should generate and review a Neighborhood Safety & Amenities Report tailored to their property of interest. This report includes crime statistics, lighting conditions, transit access, proximity to groceries, campus commute time, and student-submitted safety ratings. The report acts as a decision prerequisite, ensuring that students evaluate location quality before entering into negotiation or touring.

**Why This Action Is Essential**

The journey map revealed that safety uncertainty is one of the most emotionally intense and cognitively draining aspects of the housing process for international students. Students often struggle to differentiate safe versus unsafe areas and rely on unreliable online content or informal peer advice. This leads to bias-driven decisions, heightened anxiety, and time pressure when approaching deadlines. According to Burlton (2015), decision-enabling information assets are required at critical process touchpoints to mitigate stakeholder risk and enable capability deployment. A structured neighborhood report reduces ambiguity, simplifies risk evaluation, and directly addresses fear of scams, unfamiliarity with city geographies, and concerns about late-night safety.

Research on behavioral decision-making shows that when information is fragmented or emotionally charged, users default to heuristics rather than analytical reasoning (Wendel, 2020). Centralizing safety and amenities data in one place improves analytical processing, reduces mental effort, and supports informed decision-making at a moment of vulnerability. Burlton notes that these kinds of structured knowledge supports strengthen organizational capabilities such as Risk Mitigation, Decision Support, and Stakeholder Trust within a value stream.

## CREATE Funnel

### Cue

In the housing portal workflow, when a student clicks on a property listing, a pop-up message appears:

"Before scheduling a visit, click to generate your Neighborhood Safety & Amenities Report."
This cue aligns with Wendel's (2020) recommendation that behavioral activation must occur at the moment of intention, reducing cognitive load by embedding prompts at natural decision gates.

### Reaction

Students experience a mix of relief (receiving clarity about location quality) and mild anxiety (discovering risks or deficiencies). Emotional ambivalence is common in high-stakes decision contexts, but clarity reduces fear and improves confidence at later stages.

### Evaluation

Students evaluate credibility through university branding, clear visual risk indicators (green/yellow/red icons), and student testimonials. Burlton's capability principles emphasize high-quality, trustworthy information at critical decision junctions to prevent downstream failures.

### Ability

Ability increases when the report is automatically generated with one click, uses simple color-coded crime indicators, includes quick-read "safety tips," translation features, and transit maps. Reducing complexity improves compliance and prevents abandonment (Wendel, 2020).

### Timing

The intervention must occur before scheduling property visits — early enough to prevent wasted time on unsafe properties but late enough that students are motivated by real listings. Burlton's sequencing principle stresses that protective checkpoints need to be embedded at natural transitions in the stakeholder journey.

**Biases & Heuristics**

- Halo Effect — Students may judge a neighborhood positively based on a nice building photo.
- Availability Heuristic — Decisions based on a friend's experience in one neighborhood, not actual data.
- Optimism Bias — Underestimating risks ("It won't happen to me.").
- Bandwagon Effect — Choosing neighborhoods because "everyone lives there."

These biases distort safety perception and make students vulnerable without structured information support.

**Habits to Consider**

- Students rarely research local crime reports.
- They rely on informal WhatsApp groups for location advice.
- Most have never rented in a city before, especially where late-night transportation and lighting matter.
- Housing decisions are often made quickly without systematic evaluation of neighborhood conditions.

These habits increase vulnerability at a crucial decision stage without institutional safeguards.

**Behavior Design Recommendations**

1. **Color-Coded Risk Indicators**
   Green: safe, Yellow: mixed, Red: caution — supports rapid comprehension and reduces cognitive overload.
2. **Trust Signals**
   "Reviewed with campus police data" and "Verified student safety ratings" increase credibility and reduce hesitation.

3. **Decision Visualization**
   Maps showing street lighting, late-night bus stops, and grocery access help students understand daily life consequences.

4. **Normative Messaging**
   "Most students review a Neighborhood Safety Report before scheduling a visit" strengthens compliance expectations.

5. **Micro-Learning Content**
   Short explanations like "Understand winter commuting risks" or "What safety cameras can tell you" increase capability.

6. **Capability Alignment**
   The Safety & Amenities Report strengthens housing value stream capabilities such as Environmental Risk Mitigation, Stakeholder Guidance, and Decision Enablement (Burlton, 2015). It ensures users make safer choices while reducing institutional risk and student stress.

## Implementation Roadmap

Successful implementation of the Behavior Change Package requires phased rollout with clear milestones and stakeholder coordination. The roadmap addresses all three actions across the housing journey.

**Phase 1: Foundation (Months 1–3)**

**Action 2 Development Priority**

The Financial Readiness Assessment is developed first because it occurs earliest in the student journey. During this phase, the team collaborates with the Office of Financial Aid and International Student Services to establish realistic budget benchmarks and 30% income rule parameters. Input fields are designed with examples, autocalculation features for utilities estimates, and visual budget breakdowns using pie charts. Multilingual support for financial terminology is integrated, and mobile optimization ensures accessibility. Peer benchmark data collection begins to enable social proof messaging.

**Action 1 Foundation Work**

Simultaneously, partnerships with legal technology providers are explored for the Plain-Language Lease Review Tool's AI-powered clause analysis. The university housing office compiles a database of standard versus non-standard lease clauses common in the Boston rental market. Color-coding standards are established: red for high-risk clauses, yellow for uncommon terms, green for standard provisions.

**Action 3 Data Collection**

Crime statistics, transit maps, lighting data, and student safety review collection systems are established. Risk category definitions and color-coding standards are designed for neighborhood reports.

**Phase 2: Launch (Months 4–6)**

**Action 2 Pilot Launch**

The Financial Readiness Assessment launches as a mandatory checkpoint integrated into the housing portal. Students must complete the assessment before accessing housing listings. Real-time feedback loops display personalized affordable rent ranges. Consequence visualization features show trade-off scenarios. Progress indicators and gamified completion elements are activated. Initial user feedback is collected to identify friction points.

**Action 1 Development Completion**

The Plain-Language Lease Review Tool enters final development. The AI analysis engine is trained on Bostonarea lease templates. Micro-learning snippets are written and translated. Trust signals are integrated into the interface. Testing begins with sample lease documents.

**Action 3 Integration**

The Neighborhood Safety & Amenities Report generator is embedded in the housing portal with auto-location matching for listings.

**Phase 3: Scale (Months 7–9)**

**Full Rollout of All Actions**

All three behavior change actions become fully operational for the Fall cohort. The Financial Readiness Assessment serves as the gateway to the housing portal, the Neighborhood Safety & Amenities Report is required before scheduling viewings, and the Plain-Language Lease Review Tool is positioned as a mandatory step before lease submission.

**Process Sequencing**

The sequence follows natural stakeholder decision flows: students complete financial assessment first, then search for housing, generate safety reports before scheduling viewings, and upload leases for review before signing.

**Cue Refinement**

Contextual prompts are refined based on pilot feedback. All cues are embedded at natural workflow points to maximize activation and reduce mental effort.

**Social Proof Messaging Activation**

Normative messaging goes live across all three tools to counter status quo bias and create compliance expectations.

**Phase 4: Optimize (Months 10–12)**

**Data Analysis and Refinement**

Analysis of first full cohort data measures success against defined metrics: reduction in financially unsustainable lease commitments, decrease in lease misunderstanding incidents, improvement in student confidence ratings, and safer neighborhood selection patterns. Bias mitigation effectiveness is evaluated.

**Capability Alignment Review**

All tools are assessed as knowledge-enabling capabilities within the housing value stream. Evaluation confirms alignment with organizational capabilities including Risk Mitigation and Stakeholder Support, Information Management, Decision Enablement, and Process Efficiency.

**Continuous Improvement**

User feedback informs iterative improvements. Additional micro-learning content is developed. Language support expands based on demographic trends. Annual reporting demonstrates value delivery and return on investment.

## Conclusion

This Behavior Change Package presents three strategically designed interventions that address the most critical pain points in the international student housing journey. By applying Wendel's CREATE Funnel framework and aligning with Burlton's business architecture principles, the package delivers targeted supports at the exact decision points where students are most vulnerable to cognitive overload, emotional strain, and heuristic-driven errors.

**Action 1, the Plain-Language Lease Review Tool,** intervenes at the highest-risk moment in the housing journey—lease signing. By requiring students to upload their lease documents before commitment, it transforms uncertainty into clarity through simplified explanations, color-coded clause warnings, trust signals, and micro-learning. This intervention counters status quo bias, information avoidance, optimism bias, and authority bias while reducing cognitive load at a moment of intense pressure.

**Action 2, the Financial Readiness Assessment,** operates earlier in the journey—before students begin searching for housing. This preventive checkpoint aligns with Burlton's principle that early-stage interventions reduce costly downstream corrections. By grounding exploration in personalized budget data, real-time feedback, and consequence visualization, the tool mitigates present bias, anchoring bias, planning fallacy, overconfidence effect, and availability-driven decision errors. It enhances the "Financial Planning & Resource Allocation" capability and ensures students begin their housing search with realistic and sustainable expectations.

**Action 3, the Neighborhood Safety & Amenities Report,** provides protection at the moment students transition from browsing to scheduling property visits. It consolidates safety, transit, lighting, and amenities data into a clear, color-coded report, countering the halo effect, bandwagon effect, availability heuristic, and optimism bias. By embedding this checkpoint before any viewing

can be scheduled, the tool strengthens environmental risk mitigation and equips students with trustworthy, high-quality information that replaces fragmented online searches and peer rumors.

Collectively, these three interventions create a **layered protective architecture** across the housing value stream. The Financial Readiness Assessment establishes financial clarity at the **Awareness and Research** stages. The Neighborhood Safety & Amenities Report ensures environmental and personal safety evaluation at the **Selection and Visit Preparation** stages. The Plain-Language Lease Review Tool safeguards students at the **Commitment and Confirmation** stages. This sequencing reflects Burlton's guidance that protective checkpoints must align with natural stakeholder decision flows, reinforcing capabilities at the exact transitions where risk peaks.

Ultimately, this Behavior Change Package represents a shift from reactive problem-solving to **proactive capability-building**. By understanding the cognitive biases, emotional stressors, and habitual patterns that shape international students' housing decisions, the interventions deliver the right information, in the right form, at the right time. Together, they reduce vulnerability, increase confidence, and enable students to make safe, sustainable, and informed housing choices—allowing them to focus on academic success rather than housing stress.

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